> prisoners, as had been offered in 1919, and the second was whether to fully prosecute each crime using the mechanisms available through the Indian Penal Code.

What is evident from this exchange is that 'Irwin noted that severe punishments had been unsuccessful in upholding the laws against sedition, since radical materials continued to circulate; he also noted that if the government wanted to continue to enlist what he called "responsible" Indians, it should use a gentler approach in enforcing laws'.[1] Durba Ghosh notes how 'Lord Irwin noted with approval, "I recall the case of Gandhi a few months ago who was fined a rupee, which vindicated the law, which had only been technically infringed and left no bitterness"'.[2]

Why was there then no imposition of a fine on the Lahore conspirators as there was for Gandhi? Why was there no amnesty offered as was discussed by Lord Irwin? Why were the three in the Lahore Conspiracy Case hanged after a show trial? These questions are important because of the clear awareness by the governor-general and viceroy that physical repression was a fruitless and self-defeating endeavour on their part and that a different path, which had already been tried and tested, was likely to be more practically useful to the authorities. Lord Irwin sought advice from far and wide. He elicited the views of two trusted officials in Bengal who had previously served in Ireland and had the experience of dealing with unrest there. Both John Anderson and Charles Tegart told him that prevention was more effective than prosecution so that concentrating on removing the risk of violent attacks was altogether more constructive. On this basis, Irwin decided to endorse a policy of what he described as 'efficient despotism'. This was designed to discourage Indian nationalists from assembling and organizing around eye-catching prosecutions. This was often done in the full glare of the press as had been vividly demonstrated by the Lahore Conspiracy Case trials. It did not do the administration any good. Astonishingly, what one learns, however, is that '[s]everal weeks later, Irwin reported that figures such as Malaviya, *Nehru, and Gandhi had not made demands on behalf of political prisoners, as the viceroy had been expecting'* (emphases added).[3] If this is right then it demonstrates that the